



Parenting

Science and Practice

ISSN: 1529-5192 (Print) 1532-7922 (Online) Journal homepage: www.tandfonline.com/journals/hpar20

Navigating the Gap Between Correlational and Intervention Studies of Fatherhood and Children's Development: A Family Systems Ecological Perspective

Philip A. Cowan, Carolyn Pape Cowan, Marsha Kline Pruett & Kyle Pruett

To cite this article: Philip A. Cowan, Carolyn Pape Cowan, Marsha Kline Pruett & Kyle Pruett (2025) Navigating the Gap Between Correlational and Intervention Studies of Fatherhood and Children's Development: A Family Systems Ecological Perspective, Parenting, 25:4, 367-397, DOI: [10.1080/15295192.2024.2411503](https://doi.org/10.1080/15295192.2024.2411503)

To link to this article: <https://doi.org/10.1080/15295192.2024.2411503>



© 2024 The Author(s). Published with license by Taylor & Francis Group, LLC.



Published online: 13 Oct 2024.



Submit your article to this journal [↗](#)



Article views: 3291



View related articles [↗](#)



View Crossmark data [↗](#)



Citing articles: 5 View citing articles [↗](#)

ARTICLE

 OPEN ACCESS



Navigating the Gap Between Correlational and Intervention Studies of Fatherhood and Children's Development: A Family Systems Ecological Perspective

Philip A. Cowan, Carolyn Pape Cowan, Marsha Kline Pruett, and Kyle Pruett

SYNOPSIS

Objective. In fatherhood research, a large gap has emerged between correlation-based studies and the design of interventions to increase the quantity and quality of fathers' involvement in their families. The correlational research suggests that all family members could benefit from fatherhood intervention designs that attempt to reduce risks and strengthen protective conditions in multiple family domains—an approach consistent with family systems theories and ecological theories of child development. But most fatherhood interventions have been designed solely for fathers and focus primarily on parenting. Even in rare instances in which both parents are included in a father-focused parenting intervention, the curriculum rarely attends to the quality of relationship between the co-parents, despite the fact that this relationship is a prime correlate and predictor of father involvement and father-child relationship quality. **Design.** This narrative review describes the current gap between multidimensional correlational studies of fathers and families and the restricted designs of most father involvement interventions. We describe a family systems ecological intervention approach to bringing the correlational and intervention streams of fatherhood research closer together. **Results.** Evidence from empirical studies of correlations between risk/protective factors and outcomes supports a family systems ecological model of five domains relevant for inclusion in fatherhood intervention curricula and measurement protocols. Evaluations of interventions based on these five domains show that when both parents participate, the interventions have greater impact than interventions directed only to fathers. Fathering is not simply behavior that occurs between a father and his child. In addition to the quality of his direct interaction with his child, fathering is a dynamic product of his well-being, the quality of the relationship between the co-parents, the transmission of behavioral patterns across generations, and the balance between outside-the-family stressors and the supports available to cope with them. **Conclusions.** This family systems ecological approach has implications for theory testing, future intervention research, and policy decisions about fatherhood services.

INTRODUCTION

Most research on fatherhood is reported in studies that use data from a single point in time or that follow fathers and children over time using correlations that establish statistical connections between fathers' characteristics or parenting behaviors and children's outcomes (see Bornstein, 2019; Tamis LeMonda & Cabrera, 2013). These studies have concluded that to support children's development, at least some fathers could benefit from interventions designed to involve them more often and more positively in their children's lives (e.g., Frosch et al., 2021). Correlational studies have identified a wide array of risk and protective factors associated with fathers' parenting, especially the quality of their relationship with their co-parenting partners (M. K. Pruett et al., 2016). However, the designers of father interventions typically direct their services only to fathers and focus on only one or two domains—often father's mental health and personality characteristics and on their parenting behavior when they interact with their children (Panter-Brick et al., 2015). This restricted design occurs despite newer data showing the importance of treating the relationship between parents as essential for what parents can bring to their children's development and protection in times of crisis and strife (Khraisha et al., 2024).

Drawing on the extensive body of correlational research on fathers, we describe evidence that supports a family systems ecological model of five risk/protection domains related to fathers' involvement in the life of their families. We show how this model guides the design of our programmatic approach to fatherhood interventions in which both co-parents participate and in which the curriculum includes a focus on the quality of the co-parenting relationship. Our studies and other intervention evaluations suggest that including both mothers and fathers (or both parenting figures) in a parenting intervention produces positive results for the parents and children, perhaps more positive than parenting interventions directed to one parent, typically fathers or mothers. We conclude with a discussion of how this family systems ecological approach has important implications for future intervention research and for policy decisions about fatherhood services.

Our narrative review attempts to answer two major questions:

- (1) What correlational evidence supports the five-domain model of family functioning that guides our systemic fatherhood intervention?
- (2) Does a fatherhood intervention that includes a curriculum with multiple domains of family functioning, and includes both parenting partners, produce positive effects on fathers, mothers, and children? Are these effects stronger than those from interventions for fathers only?

WHAT CORRELATIONAL EVIDENCE SUPPORTS OUR FIVE-DOMAIN MODEL OF FAMILY FUNCTIONING?

The Need for Preventive Interventions for Couples Becoming Parents

The rising U.S. divorce rate in the 1960s and 1970s, with an associated increase in the number of single-mother families, provoked a growing concern about the negative impact of father absence on children's development. At the same time, sociological research suggested that married couples making the transition to parenthood were having a difficult time, even when fathers were present (Hobbs, 1965, 1968; Hobbs & Cole, 1976; LeMasters, 1957). The surprising conclusion by scholars who interviewed parents with young children and asked them to reflect on their experience of having made the transition to parenthood, was that this transition created a "crisis" in their relationship as a couple. Influenced by the transition-to-parenthood-as-crisis research, beginning in 1975 Cowan and colleagues (1985) mounted a pilot trial of an intervention designed to prevent, or at least reduce, the negative impact of the transition on the couple and their children. At that time, the only intervention study of this family period was one that offered support to women becoming mothers (Shereshfsky & Yarrow, 1973). Our hypothesis was that an intervention including both parents would be more effective in easing this transition for the couple by getting men involved early on.

The Emergence of Family Systems Theories

Our choices concerning what the curriculum should include were influenced by the emergence of family systems theories, which developed initially to understand and treat serious mental illness (Bowen, 1974; Minuchin, 1974; Watzlawick et al., 1967). These theories asserted that each family domain operated in an interactive system in which changes in any domain of family life would create disequilibrium that leads to changes in other family domains. Later, Bronfenbrenner (1979) described a bioecological system with five subsystems: the microsystem included family, school, and neighborhood systems with which the child had direct contact; the mesosystem described interactions among the microsystem components; the exosystem included forces outside the nuclear family such as parents' workplace or government institutions in which children were not directly involved but their development was affected; the macrosystem described the laws, customs, and culture and country of residence; and the chronosystem included factors that affect families over time and across generations. The curriculum of the intervention P. A. Cowan et al. (1985) designed for couples making the transition to parenthood focused on (1) the nuclear family existing within Bronfenbrenner's microsystem, (2) the mesosystem with interactions among the family components—especially the system of interactions among father,

mother, and child), and (3) the exosystem of factors outside the nuclear family that affect family members, and the transmission of behavior patterns across generations.

Five Domains of Family Risk and Protection: Evidence from Correlational Studies

The broad domains of family functioning outlined in family systems theories did not provide guidance about specific risks and protective factors to address in a curriculum designed to include fathers and strengthen families in the early years of childrearing. Research available in the mid-1970s suggested a five-domain model of risk and protective factors that interact with each other to affect family members and their relationships (P. A. Cowan et al., 2022): (1) parenting behavior; (2) the couple; (3) individual health and well-being; (4) transmission of patterns across generations; and (5) outside the family stress and support.

In subsequent years, a number of investigators developed ecological systems models of family functioning, including a family process model by Belsky (1984, 1991), studies of Iowa families by Conger et al. (2000), general models of fatherhood by Cabrera et al. (2007, K. Pruett's and Pruett (2009) focus on co-parenting, and Parke and Cookston's (Glasser & Lerner-Geva, 2019) comprehensive summary of fatherhood research. All of these models were based on data from correlational studies with the exception of J. P. McHale et al. (2013) and Feinberg et al. (2014) who used systems models to guide their intervention programs for parents early in the transition to parenthood.

Since the first formulation of the model, many correlational studies have provided evidence that variables in each of the five domains are associated with positive functioning in fathers, mothers, couples, parenting behavior, and the child. Here we present a few examples from correlational studies that support a systems model of risk and protective factors associated with the performance of fathers' role in the family.

Fathers' Parenting Behavior. The literature on the association between fathers' parenting and children's cognitive, social, and emotional development has been more limited than for mothers, but it has been emerging in quantity and quality (see Bornstein, 2019; Tamis LeMonda & Cabrera, 2013) and includes studies that derive from a range of theoretical perspectives. Attachment theorists found that fathers who respond sensitively to their children have children who are more likely to be characterized as securely attached (Lucassen et al., 2011). Studies of parenting style, initially stimulated by Baumrind (1971), find that in contrast with fathers whose parenting style is authoritarian or laissez faire, fathers whose parenting is authoritative—warm and responsive but able to set appropriate limits—have children who develop

more positive academic and interpersonal skills (Larzelere et al., 2012). Behavior theorists find that fathers of children who have fewer behavior problems reinforce positive behavior and avoid reinforcing negative behavior (Patterson, 2002).

The Couple Relationship. Satir (1972) asserted that parents together function as “architects of the family,” and Minuchin (1974) focused on the importance of modifying the couple relationship when treating families in which a child is the “identified patient.” How parents relate to each other has two interconnected aspects—being both a responsive partner and an effective co-parent, intertwined and mutually reinforcing aspects of their relationship.

Beginning in the 1990s, it became clear that there were consistent correlations between the quality of parents’ relationship with each other and their children’s developmental outcomes. The negative association of parental conflict and children’s behavior problems is a ubiquitous finding in child and family development research (e.g., Zemp et al., 2016). Conflict between the parents includes interactions that affect children directly (Camara & Resnick, 1988; Harold & Sellers, 2018) and indirectly through negative influences on the fathers’ involvement and the quality of parenting (P. Cowan et al., 2009; M. K. Pruett et al., 2016). The single best predictor of fathers’ family involvement is the quality of the father’s relationship with the child’s mother, a finding that holds for never married, married, cohabiting, separated, and divorced co-parents (Carlson et al., 2008; M. Pruett & Johnston, 2004). Furthermore, when couples communicate effectively with each other, their parenting is more sensitive and attuned to the needs of their children (e.g., Adler-Baeder et al., 2013).

A distinct sub-category of couple relationships, the co-parenting relationship—separate from the romantic aspects of couples/partners—was identified in family systems research of the 1980s (Minuchin & Fishman, 1981) and has been studied a great deal since that time (J. McHale et al., 2012, 2013; Minuchin, 2018; K. Pruett & Pruett, 2009). The term “co-parents” has often been used to describe the relationship between parents who are divorced, but it is also used commonly, and we employ it here, to refer to the relationship between any two adults who share the rearing of their child(ren). It has long been theorized and demonstrated that the co-parenting relationship serves as the executive subsystem of the family, functioning to regulate parenting behaviors and family well-being (Minuchin, 1974). Whereas couple and co-parent relationships are conceptually distinguishable, the two are interconnected in that positive co-parenting is correlated with higher quality intimate partner relationships (Amato & Afifi, 2006; Cabrera et al., 2012; Cummings et al., 2010; Lamela et al., 2016). Co-parenting partners—married and unmarried—support their children best when they are cooperative and collaborative in child rearing (Knox et al., 2011; J. McHale et al., 2012; Rienks et al., 2011;

Schulz et al., 2009). Observational data show that when co-parents are more cooperative, their parenting strategies are more sensitive and less harsh (Altenburger & Schoppe-Sullivan, 2021; Caldera & Lindsey, 2006; Favez et al., 2015; Jeong-Kyun & Becher, 2019; Wang et al., 2023). Conversely, in families with unresolved parental conflict, parental sensitivity is lower than in more collaborative parent dyads (Favez et al., 2015). In summary, co-parenting is associated with children's development, in that cooperative co-parenting is associated with lower levels of children's internalizing and externalizing behaviors (Fivaz-Depeursinge & Philipp, 2014; Steinbach, 2023) and healthier child outcomes in general (Alcaniz et al., 2022).

Being the best parent one can be is greatly assisted by having an effective co-parent and a responsive partner, although this arrangement is not always possible. Even when there are two parenting figures, in some cases co-parenting collaboration breaks down (Wang et al., 2023). Both mothers and fathers can act as "gatekeepers," but maternal gatekeeping restricts paternal involvement when mothers monitor and control access to their child in ways that keep fathers out of the informational loop and create fewer opportunities for fathers to spend time alone with their child, make decisions pertaining to their development, or engage in teaching and play that fosters parental understanding and sensitivity to the child's needs (C. P. Cowan et al., 2007; Pruett & Drozd, in press). Austin et al. (2013) elaborated on how gatekeeping dynamics may be facilitative or restrictive of involvement by the other parent. Gatekeeping may stem from protectiveness that is justified or unjustified, depending on whether the restrictions stem from legitimate concerns about the other parent's competence or capacity to keep the child safe or from projected anxiety of the restricting parent. Whatever the underlying rationale for restrictive behaviors of mothers or fathers, the outcome is similar in that it diminishes the other parent's presence and influence in the child's life and opens the door to strained relationships between the child and the parent who is outside the gate.

Individual Mental Health and Well-Being. Research on parents' mental health confirms that psychological vulnerability in one or both parents, in the forms of diagnosed psychopathology (Fisher, 2017), insecure adult attachments (Mikulincer & Shaver, 2017), or anxiety and negative personality characteristics (e.g., Mestermann et al., 2023), is associated with disengaged, negative father-child relationships and long-term behavior problems in the children. Furthermore, consistent with family systems theory, untreated mental health problems in father, mother, or child can lead to difficulties in the couple, parenting, or co-parenting domains. A meta-analysis focusing on fathers showed that paternal depression is related to fathers' negative parenting behaviors (Cheung & Theule, 2019), and predicts child behavioral difficulties, even after controlling for both early maternal depression and later

paternal depression (Fletcher et al., 2011). Furthermore, paternal depression after birth is associated negatively with couple relationship quality (Bruno et al., 2020) and children's behavior problems at 36 months and psychiatric disorders at 7 years, again adjusting for maternal depression (Glasser & Lerner-Geva, 2019).

Transmission of Patterns Across Generations. Family behavioral and relationship patterns tend to be repeated across generations if there are no efforts to break negative relationship cycles. In a specific example with regard to parenting, adults who experienced maltreatment from their parents are more likely to abuse their children (Cicchetti & Toth, 2010). A longitudinal demonstration of intergenerational transmission comes from the Berkeley Intergenerational Study of four generations of families that began in 1928 and continued to the children's adulthood (Caspi & Elder, 1988). The intergenerational cycle starts with an irritable, unstable child who grows up to be an irritable, angry adult, who generates tension in his or her marriage. Husbands and wives in such marriages tend to be less warm and harsher as parents, and in the next generation their children tend to have behavior problems and to grow up as irritable, unstable individuals who form conflictual marriages and function as harsh or disengaged parents to their children. Early trauma symptoms of both fathers and mothers are related to child PTSD symptoms (Lünnemann et al., 2019). Intergenerational patterns are manifest in families from a number of cultural groups. In an Israeli sample, intergenerational effects of paternal trauma and maternal secondary trauma were especially salient for sons' development (Solomon & Zerach, 2020). In a Chinese migrant sample, fathers' rather than mothers' perceptions of co-parenting helped to account for the transmission of anxiety from fathers and mothers to their migrant children (Liu et al., 2021).

Outside-The-Family: Stress and Support. In families in which parents are economically stressed by unemployment or jobs that pay less than a living wage, the children also suffer. The negative health and mental health effects on children of having fathers who do not support them financially are well documented (Baughman, 2017; Nepomnyaschy et al., 2012). The importance of family systems emerges again in studies that show indirect effects of economic stress on children—a result of cascading difficulties, including strained parents who are less effective as partners and co-parents (Conger et al., 2000; Parke et al., 2004), and in worst case scenarios, more likely to become abusive parents (Lawson et al., 2020). Economic and other life stressors can be buffered by support from positive relationships inside and outside the family (Chen et al., 2017; Cohen & McKay, 2020; Cutrona, 1996; Keneski et al., 2017).

Conclusion from a Family Systems Ecological Perspective on Fatherhood, Based on Correlational Studies

Parke's et al. (2019, p. 143) review conveys the core of our argument: "... as this review underscores, a wide range of factors from biological to individual, couple, family, community, and culture operate together in determining father behavior." In the 1970s and in the subsequent conceptual systemic models of fatherhood (e.g., Belsky, 1984; Cabrera et al., 2014), the models were based on the assumption that the separate correlations between fathers' behavior and children's adaptation found in different studies were dynamically interconnected, but there have been very few studies of whether this assumption is supported by empirical research. Some of the studies described below show that domains of family functioning are in fact correlated with each other. Second, a multiple domain fatherhood model had not been tested in intervention studies that could help to validate the systems approach by showing that intervention-induced changes in one domain are accompanied by simultaneous changes in other domains.

Figure 1 provides a schematic version of that family systems model of fatherhood. In this model, grandparents and events in the families in which parents grow up shape the developmental trajectories of men and women who become parents. Their personalities and behaviors influence and are influenced by their relationship as a couple and their parenting relationship with their child. All of these factors play roles in the quantity and quality of fathers' involvement with their children. The family trajectory and all the relationships within it are affected by stresses and supports from friendships, economic circumstances, and institutions outside the nuclear family. This model is framed in gendered depiction of parents who are romantic partners, but we have some evidence that it applies to same-sex non-romantic partners as well (P. A. Cowan et al., 2022).

We are not claiming that only five domains of factors affect fathers and their children. Within the family we know that sibling relationships are another important family domain and that fathers and mothers rarely behave in the same way to each of their children (Jensen et al., 2023). Outside the nuclear family, we have not included Bronfenbrenner's concerns with schools and other systems with which the child has direct contact, and we have omitted his macrosystem dimension that describes the impact of culture and country of residence on the family. The domains focused on have evidence from cross disciplinary research and can be studied systematically. In the following section, we describe our own and others' longitudinal studies of fatherhood interventions and programs that employ a couples group modality, with curricula that address multiple risk and protective components of the family system.

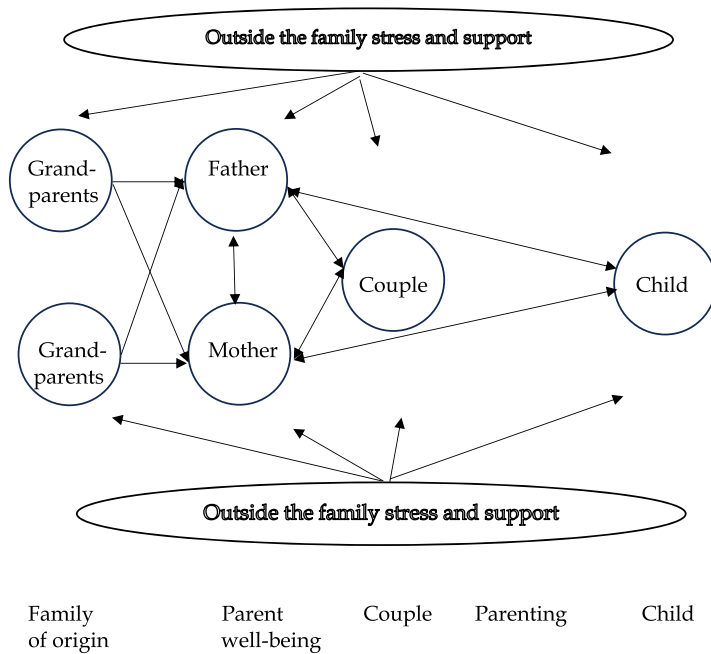


Figure 1 A conceptual family systems model of fatherhood and child outcomes family parent couple parenting child of origin well-being.

DOES A MULTIDOMAIN CURRICULUM AND AN INTERVENTION MODALITY THAT INCLUDES BOTH PARENTING PARTNERS HAVE POSITIVE EFFECTS ON THE FAMILY?

Supporting Father Involvement Intervention Studies

In this section we describe 9 evaluation studies that we, Philip Cowan, Carolyn Pape Cowan, Marsha Kline Pruett, Kyle Pruett and colleagues have conducted that use a similar curriculum, intervention format, and set of measurements. We have summarized the main features of each of these studies in [Table 1](#).

The Supporting Father Involvement manualized intervention (SFI; P. Cowan et al., 2009; Kline Pruett et al., 2019) has evolved over time, but its central features have been guided by the multidomain model of microlevel family dynamics outlined above and remained relatively constant in our work over the past five decades. Groups of four to seven co-partners (fathers and mothers or fathers and other co-parents), led by clinically experienced male and female co-leader teams, meet with couples weekly for 16 weeks. Each week, after an open-ended beginning in which participants are invited to raise any positive or troubling issues for discussion, the structured curriculum covers one of the five domains, with an explicit focus at the outset on the importance of father engagement for the couple/co-parents and for children's development and well-being. The 2-hour meetings include brief presentations and discussions about the curriculum content, games, role-plays, video

Table 1 Summary of the authors' fatherhood intervention studies.

Reference number	Number Targeted of couples	Targeted income level	Age of children at baseline	Length of follow-up	RCT or Pre-post	Main findings
1	96	None	In utero	6 years. To 1 st grade	RCT	Control: Marital satisfaction declined over 5 years Intervention: Marital satisfaction maintained over 5 years
2a	100	None	6 years	3 years. To 1 st grade	RCT	Control: Negative changes in marital quality, parenting, child outcomes Intervention with parenting focus: parenting improved, children had fewer internalizing problems and reported more positive well-being Intervention with couple relationship focus: Marital conflict and violence declined, parenting improved, children had fewer internalizing problems and higher achievement scores
2b			16 years	10 years		Intervention with couple relationship focus: 10-year positive effects on both parents' marital satisfaction and the children's hyperactivity and aggression
3	289	Low	Newborn to 12 years	18 months RCT	RCT	Control: Marital satisfaction decline, children with increased internalizing and externalizing problems Fathers only intervention: Fathers more involved with children, no increase in children's behavior problems Couples intervention: Fathers more involved with children, no increase in children's behavior problems, decreased parenting stress, and no decline in marital satisfaction
4	236	Low	Newborn to 12 years	18 months	Pre-Post	Couples intervention only: No decline in marital satisfaction, positive change over time in 10 of 11 measures used in Study 3, including reduction in violence, in children's behavior problems, and increase in income. Household income increased
5	239	Low	Newborn to 12 years	18 months	RCT	Structured equation models (SEM) comparing intervention and controls: Intervention participants showed more decline than controls in latent variables measuring couple conflict at the 6 and 18 month follow-ups. This intervention-induced reduction in conflict had indirect positive effects on reductions in harsh parenting and children's behavior problems. Household income increased. There were no differences in intervention impact on Child Welfare-referred and Community samples
6	164	None	Newborn to 10 years		Pre-Post	Couples intervention only: Reductions in depression, couple conflict and violent problem-solving, parenting stress and children's aggression; increases in couple relationship satisfaction and fathers' involvement with their children

(Continued)

Table 1 (Continued).

Reference number	Number Targeted of couples	Targeted income level	Age of children at baseline	Length of follow-up	RCT or Pre-post	Main findings
7	97	Low	6 months to 11 years	7 months	Pre-Post	Couples intervention only: Decrease in personal distress, couple conflict and violent problem-solving, parenting stress and a reduction in children's behavior problems
8	60	None	Difficult to soothe infants	7 months	RCT	Compared with controls, intervention participants showed reduced personal and couple distress, and infants were described as easier to soothe
9	1042	Low	Newborn to 12 years	12 months	RCT	Structured equation models (SEM) comparing intervention and controls: Intervention participants showed more decline than controls in latent variables measuring couple conflict at the 12-month follow-up. This intervention-induced reduction in conflict had indirect positive effects on reductions in harsh parenting and children's behavior problems. Compared with controls, fathers' economic self-sufficiency increased

presentations, and suggestions of “homework” for the next week about what to notice or try at home. In contrast with didactic parenting classes, the role of the group leaders is to provide a safe setting and a curriculum structure in which couples can explore dilemmas in their attempts to become the parents and partners they are hoping to be.

Beginning in the 1970s, our couples group intervention approach has climbed the ladder of risk in terms of the samples recruited—from couples making the transition to first-time parenthood to multiracial groups of low-income parents and co-parents of children under 12, some already in the Child Welfare System because of previous domestic violence, child abuse, or neglect. From its roots in California, the groups have now been conducted in other U.S. states, in Canada, the United Kingdom, and Malta. There are trials in process in Israel and Kyrgyzstan and under development in China. Each trial of SFI has been systematically evaluated, some with pre-post studies of change, and some with Randomized Controlled Trials.

Almost all couples' education and parenting classes assume that working with parents will improve the lives of children, but they rarely provide systematic data on child outcomes (a prominent exception is Feinberg et al., 2014). A rare feature of all of the SFI evaluations is our documentation of the effects of parents' involvement in the program on their children's behavior and academic competence. A second feature is that the analysis of intervention effects in most of the studies attempts to capture the systemic connections among the domains affected by the intervention. In addition to the usual

practice of examining the direct effects of the intervention on each domain one by one (e.g., separate analyses of how participation affects father's depressive symptoms, or marital quality or parenting behavior), we examine the indirect pathways through which intervention-induced changes in one domain affect other domains. For example, we find that when parents' participation results in lower levels of depression in the parents or improved couple relationship quality (direct effects), the fathers become more effective parents and co-parents and their children show fewer behavior problems (indirect effects) than children in comparable families with no intervention (P. A. Cowan et al., 2022).

Two early versions of our intervention followed (1) middle-class and working-class couples through the transition to first-time parenthood and (2) through a first child's transition to formal schooling. The first (C. P. Cowan et al., 1985; P. Cowan et al., 2009 see Study 1 in Table 1), a Randomized Controlled Trial (RCT), found that participants in the couples group intervention maintained couples' marital satisfaction over a 5-year period from pregnancy to the end of first grade, whereas the no-treatment couples in the control group, on average, experienced the decline in marital satisfaction typical of longitudinal studies without intervention components (Twenge et al., 2003). Perhaps a more graphic way of describing the impact was found in the analysis of the small number of couples that showed *gains* in marital satisfaction at the 18-month postpartum follow-up. In the no-treatment group 18% of the couples showed higher marital satisfaction scores 18 months after becoming parents, whereas that number was 38% for the couples who participated in the intervention.

The second intervention trial (P. A. Cowan et al., 2005; see Study 2a in Table 1), also an RCT, began when a new sample of families' first children were about to make the transition to elementary school and followed the families at the end of the children's kindergarten and first grade years. In this transition to school study, parents were randomly assigned to one of two intervention conditions: (1) during the weekly check-in opening discussions in the groups where parents provided the content, the leaders in one condition listened for and focused on parenting issues, while (2) leaders in the other condition listened for and emphasized couple relationship issues. Using observational measures of separate father-child, mother-child, and couple interactions in our project playroom, the study documented positive effects for the intervention participants on the parents' relationships as couples and on their parenting strategies from pre-school until the end of their children's first grade year. Compared with a consultation-only control group, couples in the group intervention were rated by observers (uninformed about the families' intervention condition) as showing reduced coldness and anger from pre- to post-intervention as they discussed an issue on which they disagreed. In addition, both fathers and mothers who participated in the group intervention and were

observed in a playroom session with their children showed more authoritative behavior—higher ratings of warmth, structure, limit-setting, and respect for the child’s autonomy, and lower ratings of coldness, and non-responsiveness—than parents in the no-treatment control condition. Compared with participants in the control group, fathers’ parenting style in both the parenting-focused and couple-focused conditions became less authoritarian over time—less harsh and warmer—and their children were rated by first grade teachers as showing fewer externalizing and internalizing behaviors. In addition, the couples-focused check-in condition led to a decline in observed conflict between the parents during their later private discussion of a disagreement, an outcome that did not occur in the control group couples. A follow-up when the children were in high school (C. P. Cowan et al., 2011; see Study 2b in [Table 1](#)) revealed that intervention participation continued to have positive effects on the couple and the child 10 years after the parents entered the study.

In response to an appeal from the Office of Child Abuse Prevention (OCAP) in California’s Department of Social Services, Cowan, Cowan, K. Pruett and Pruett (2009) adopted the same 5-domain theoretical model for the design of the Supporting Father Involvement interventions, with a curriculum redesigned with a focus on fathers in low-income, low-resourced families. That agency was eager to find a more effective and replicable way of reducing child abuse and neglect by engaging fathers positively with their children, and the Supporting Father Involvement (SFI) intervention was created with that goal in mind. The group intervention included both parents and the curriculum followed the structure of our earlier couples group studies addressing the five-domain risk and protective factors. The original curriculum was slightly modified with a more explicit focus on fathers’ relationships with their children and with the mothers of their children, one that would be appropriate for groups that differ in terms of ethnicity, geographic cultures, and SES. With more than 200 families in each of three SFI studies over 10 years, observational assessments of in-person couple and parent-child interaction at pretest and posttest were no longer feasible, and so the data reported in each domain come from parent reports.

The third study (P. Cowan et al., 2009; see Study 3 in [Table 1](#)) recruited low-income, low-resourced parents. Staff, consisting of a director, group leaders, family resource staff, and a data manager, were placed in each of five California Family Resource Centers in rural and urban low-income counties. Participants were mostly low-income and Hispanic (from 50%-66% of the samples), with a number of low-income European American and African American families as well. Given that we were exploring a focus on the co-parent relationship, we compared couples who received no SFI services over 18 months with a randomly assigned set of groups attended by fathers only (whose co-parent consented to take part in the study) and another randomly

assigned set of groups attended by both parent figures. In measures of individual well-being, couple relationship and parenting quality at the 18-month follow-up, the no-treatment couples remained stable or showed more negative functioning, especially in parent-reported behavior problems shown by their children—increased aggression, hyperactivity, shy withdrawn behavior, and sadness/depression. Children whose fathers were in the fathers-only groups did not increase in behavior problems and their fathers became more involved over time in the daily tasks of childrearing such as feeding, dressing, bathing, playing, and dealing with doctors, but both mothers' and fathers' satisfaction with their relationship as a couple declined over the 18 months of the study. By contrast, in the groups attended by both parenting figures, fathers became more involved with the care of the children, both parents' ratings of parenting stress declined, there was no decline in either parent's satisfaction with their couple or co-parent relationship, and the children's behavior problems remained stable.

A fourth intervention study (P. A. Cowan et al., 2014; see Study 4 in Table 1), also funded by the California Office of Child Abuse Prevention, was offered in the same low-income counties, but this time it included European American, Hispanic, and a larger sample of African American parents. Because we had found in the previous study that fathers-only groups and the no-treatment group were not as effective as the couples groups, this study recruited only couples for the SFI group intervention. The central goal was to determine whether the earlier result could be replicated in a new sample. In this study of 236 couples, the results of attending the 16-week couples groups revealed statistically significant positive changes over 18 months for the group participants.

Next, we recruited community low-income couples to a new SFI intervention, and for the first time included couples that had been previously involved in referrals to the Child Welfare Service (CWS) but who were not currently engaged in violence, abuse, or neglect (Kline Pruett et al., 2019; see Study 5 in Table 1). This time, each condition included some couples that had been involved with CWS services and others that had not. Altogether, 239 couples were randomly assigned to immediate enrollment in the couples group intervention or offered a chance to enroll in a group 6 months later (the wait-list control). A Structural Equation Model showed that, in contrast with those in the delayed condition, parents who completed the immediate intervention reported a reduction in couple conflict 6 months after they entered the study (a direct effect). One year later, there was a cascade of indirect effects. The reduction in negative couple communication (disagreement about couple issues, disagreement about co-parenting issues, violent problem-solving) was followed by reductions between the 6-month and 18-month follow-ups in harsh parenting (yelling, spanking, slapping, hitting as a response to child wrongdoing) and reductions in children's aggressive behaviors and symptoms

of depression. Outcomes were as positive for the child-welfare-referred families as for families recruited from the community, including reductions in the parents' violent reactions in disagreements (yelling, pushing, hitting each other).

Three additional Supporting Father Involvement intervention trials have been conducted outside the United States. All three found results consistent with those reported above. A replication with 106 couples at four sites in Calgary, Alberta, Canada (M. K. Pruett et al., 2016; see Study 6 in Table 1) used a pre—post intervention design and enlisted primarily middle-class Caucasian families, both rural and urban participants. Twelve months after entering the study, SFI-Alberta group participants showed positive change on 9 of the 11 measures used in prior SFI studies in the United States, including fathers' involvement in care of the children, parenting stress, and the quality of the co-parent and parent—child relationships. In the United Kingdom, two evaluations of the original SFI curriculum renamed Parents as Partners were conducted. A pre-post evaluation of the Parents as Partners intervention for 97 low-income parent pairs from varied ethnic backgrounds, referred by family agencies from more than 10 sites (Casey et al., 2017; see Study 7 in Table 1), revealed reductions in parents' reports of depression and anxiety, parenting stress, and violence when discussing a topic on which they disagreed. In Malta (Study 8 in Table 1), Parents as Partners recruited 58 co-parents of difficult-to-soothe infants and used a Random Controlled Trial design. Compared with parents in the no-treatment condition, parents in the couples group intervention reported reduced couple conflict occurring in front of the child, a reduction in parent-child dysfunctional interactions, and a reduction in problematic behaviors in the children (submitted for publication).

Finally, we reported on a fatherhood intervention in Oklahoma (P. A. Cowan et al., 2022; see Study 9 in Table 1) that used our model and measures to evaluate a couples-based fatherhood intervention. The curriculum included some materials from SFI but more items from the PREP program by Stanley et al. (1999). Over 5 years, the RCT design divided 1,042 very low-income co-parenting couples into 621 intervention condition co-parenting couples in small groups and 421 no-treatment controls, all followed up 12 months after they entered the study. The intervention involved 6 3-hour group sessions led by male-female teams and covering topics in each of the five domains. Intervention fathers were also offered an opportunity to participate in a 2-week employment workshop. The sample was ethnically diverse including African American, European American, Hispanic, Asian American, and Native American participants. The SEM analysis was based on latent variable measures similar to one of the California SFI studies (Kline Pruett et al., 2019), and yielded very similar results. Reductions in couple/co-parent conflict in the intervention sample (a direct effect) were associated with parent reports of reductions in harsh parenting, which were, in turn, associated with reductions

in children's externalizing and internalizing behavior problems and increases in employment and income (indirect effects).

Across studies, almost all of the intervention effects we reported were similar for fathers and their co-parents. That is, an added benefit of including both partners in a fatherhood intervention is the increased potential benefits to the child by enhancing both parents' parenting effectiveness as well as the quality of their relationship as a couple or co-parenting team.

The SFI intervention model has been applied to several other non-traditional samples, mostly without systematic evaluation so far. Indigenous groups in Northern and Southern Alberta have been using the SFI group intervention and report that it is culturally appropriate, useful, and enriching. Incarcerated young fathers and parents in Fresno and Santa Cruz, CA, appeared to benefit from participation, as did young African American and Latino men with little prior interaction with their children in Hartford, CT. The Parents as Partners program in the United Kingdom conducted two groups for lesbian couples, and one group for lesbian couples was offered in California, and all three were described by the staff as successful and appreciated by the parents (personal communication). Unfortunately, at this time we have no systematic evaluation data from parents in which one or both identify as LGBTQ+. Given that the curriculum of our five-domain risk/protective model applies to individuals without regard to sexual orientation or gender identity and is non-prescriptive, and given reported clinical impressions and testimonies from parents and facilitators in these pilot trials, we are optimistic that this approach is appropriate for a broad range of families that include grandparents as parents, adoptive families, and kin networks. Clearly, our optimism must be subject to systematic empirical confirmation. Also, as we discuss further in the section on limitations, it will be important to gather more information about the application of the models to families living in non-Western countries and cultures.

An emphasis on the benefits of adding fathers to parenting interventions usually conducted for mothers could imply that this intervention approach is relevant only to traditional heterosexual couples who are biological parents of children in a nuclear family unit, but we have evidence to broaden the picture somewhat. About 30% of the co-parenting teams participating in Supporting Father Involvement programs were comprised of a non-biological father and his co-parent. Furthermore, from 3% to 15% of the co-parents, depending on the study, were non-intimate partners (e.g., a father and the child's grandparent, a father and his sibling, a father and a friend who is centrally involved in rearing the child). Analyses indicate that there were similar positive effects of participating in the intervention for co-parenting teams both with intimate and non-intimate partners.

Other Couple-Focused Father Involvement Interventions

These interventions are part of a very small number of systematically evaluated fatherhood interventions that include both parents and assess potential effects of parents' participation on their children's development. The impact of the co-parenting relationship on young children's outcomes has been tested directly by the Family Foundations Program in Pennsylvania (Feinberg & Kan, 2008; Feinberg & Jones 2018)—an RCT of an 8-session couples group for middle-class new parents with a special emphasis on managing or reducing disagreements about their children through the development of communication skills and problem solving. The program also included modules on partners sharing their expectations about parenting an infant. In the intervention condition, parents' reports at 3.5-years postpartum revealed more effective parenting and increases in positive co-parenting and at the 5- to 7-year follow-up fewer behavior problems in the children (Kan & Feinberg, 2014).

J. P. McHale et al. (2015) six-session program designed for low-income parents in Florida called Figuring It Out for the Child produced increases in 8 of 12 measures of co-parenting collaboration. Three other studies in different U.S. locales showed that interventions with couples in groups produced positive outcomes in one or more family relationship domains: the quality of mothers' parenting (Besnard et al., 2009), fathers' involvement (Rienks et al., 2011), and co-parenting conflict, fathers' involvement, and positive discipline practices from pre- to post-intervention (Adler-Baeder et al., 2013). Here, too, there is evidence that interventions for couples who are parents of young children have positive effects on the whole family.

Reports by Mathematica of the Parents and Children Together (PACT) programs describe the effects of two federally funded "healthy marriage programs" (Moore et al., 2018) and four "responsible fatherhood programs" (Avellar et al., 2018). A comparison of the two reports reveals results consistent with our SFI findings: The fatherhood programs (for fathers only) showed positive effects on parenting but *not* on co-parenting, whereas the couple relationship programs showed positive effects on both couple relationship quality *and* co-parenting.

DISCUSSION

In this review we described the gap between correlational studies of multiple factors associated with the quantity and quality of fathers' parenting and the design of interventions that aim to increase fathers' active involvement in the family. We have attempted to demonstrate the utility of narrowing this gap by applying family systems models to fatherhood intervention curricula and practice. Here we return to the two specific questions raised in the introduction to this paper.

What Correlational Evidence Supports Our Five-Domain Model of Family Functioning?

Many examples of research, including our own studies, indicate strong support for the claim that variables in each of the five domains are correlated with the quantity and quality of fathers' involvement with their children. Furthermore, using Structural Equation Models we showed that variables from these domains are intercorrelated: parents' depression and other measures of personal distress, central aspects of couple relationship quality (e.g., conflict and violence), parenting quality, children's behavior problems, and life stressors and economic supports. Thus, there are theoretically and empirically supported reasons for concluding that father involvement and parenting exist in a network of systemic connections among family members and their relationships with each other. But correlational studies do not provide proof for the widely-held assumption that any of these domains are causally related to outcomes sought by service providers. For that conclusion we need to test hypotheses with systematically-evaluated interventions.

Does a Multi-Domain Curriculum and an Intervention Modality That Includes Both Parenting Partners Have Positive Effects on the Family?

The SFI five-domain model has been used to design fatherhood intervention groups and evaluation protocols for 9 studies, six RCTs, and 3 pretest to posttest follow-ups, conducted in four countries with ethnically diverse participants. One of these studies tested the five-domain model on a different intervention curriculum (Study 9). Our main conclusion from these evaluations was that interventions attended by both parenting partners produced positive effects or reductions in negative effects on family functioning: reduced symptoms of depression, co-parent conflict, harsh parenting, and children's behavior problems. In all of the trials with low-income families an unexpected finding was that couples participating in the intervention reported greater yearly income or employment. While the primary justification for encouraging fathers to become more positively involved in the family is that children will benefit, very few fatherhood studies have gathered data on child outcomes, making the fact that there were positive effects on the children in the couples groups we evaluated that were attended by both parents noteworthy.

In addition to the fact that the intervention guided by our five-domain model has been helpful to the couples that have participated in the studies conducted so far, we can interpret the evaluation results as tests of causal hypotheses. The RCT designs used in 6 of the studies allow us to conclude that intervention-induced reductions in personal distress and couple relationship conflict have causal effects on the quality of fathers' and mothers' relationships and on their parenting behavior.

An unresolved question is whether the addition of a co-parent participant makes it more effective than group interventions that include only fathers. Only one of our studies approached that question directly. It evaluated a random assignment to fathers-only groups *or* couples groups with the same curriculum and found the couples groups to be more effective (P. Cowan et al., 2009, See study 3, Table 1) in the sense that increased father involvement in both conditions was accompanied by maintenance of couple relationship quality only in the groups attended by both parents. Similarly, Rienks et al. (2011) found that, compared with the control condition, father involvement declined when only mothers attended the groups and attempted to convey the information to their partners at home, but it increased when both partners attended the groups together. Finally, an international review of hundreds of couple-, fatherhood-, and family-based intervention studies concluded that the few fatherhood interventions that offered group meetings for both parenting partners led to more positive increases in reports of father-child relationship involvement with their children *and* in co-parenting relationship quality (Panter-Brick et al., 2015).

Most parent intervention research concerned with the issue of two-parent versus one-parent participation in groups evaluates adding fathers to interventions usually attended by mothers—not quite the same question as adding mothers/co-parents to fatherhood interventions. Studies of therapists in Australia and the United States having difficulty treating aggressive children find that mothers report that they were more successful managing their children's aggression when fathers were added to the mother-child intervention (Brody & Forehand, 1985; Dadds et al., 1987; Webster-Stratton, 1985). A Canadian intervention study (Besnard et al., 2009) that randomly assigned participants to couples groups, mothers groups, or a control group found that the quality of mothers' parenting improved only when both parents were involved. A meta-analysis of several different types of parent-training interventions in the United States by Lundahl et al. (2008) reached the same conclusion. A meta-analysis of attachment interventions by Bakermans-Kranenburg et al. (2003, p. 211) concluded that "In the total set of studies, interventions involving fathers appear to be more effective than interventions focusing on mothers only" but also cited two studies that did not fit their generalization. These intervention studies, then, using narrative reviews, meta-analyses, and single-study RCT designs come to similar conclusions. Whatever the outcomes of parenting classes or therapeutic interventions for mothers, including fathers represents a value-added approach to strengthening the relationships between the parents and with their children. We conclude that there is beginning research suggesting that adding co-parents to interventions designed to enhance fatherhood will increase the impact of the interventions on the family, but additional studies systematically comparing fathers-only

and two co-parent conditions will be needed to address this question more directly.

LIMITATIONS AND DIRECTIONS FOR FUTURE INTERVENTION RESEARCH

Methodological Issues

Almost all surveys based on research studies wind up with the statement that “more research is needed.” We certainly endorse that conclusion here. In this review, we have described only a limited number of intervention studies with limited, although heterogeneous, participant samples, and limited variations in curricula and outcome measures. In the five-domain general model, future research is needed to identify whether other specific aspects of family functioning are affected by and critical to fatherhood interventions. As we noted, additional within-family domains include siblings, and extra-family domains include schools, neighborhoods, countries, and cultures that could affect positive and negative ways in which fathers interact with their children. Recently, Hrdy (2024) a biological anthropologist summarizes new research on fatherhood, suggesting that in fathers who are actively involved with babies, there are significant changes in hormones (e.g., reductions in testosterone and increases in oxytocin) and brain functions (e.g., increased activity in cortical areas). Certainly, this is a new domain associated with father involvement, but we don’t yet know whether these biological changes trigger fathers to become more active parents, or whether parental involvement creates changes in hormone output and brain function. And, as yet, there are no clear interventions in biological functioning that are known to affect father involvement.

There is ample evidence that including both fathers and mothers in parenting interventions has a positive impact on the participants, and some evidence that this impact may be greater than interventions with fathers alone. Supporting Father Involvement, and the other multi-domain interventions we described, represent the beginning stages of a research enterprise needed to bring a systems perspective derived from correlational studies of fatherhood to the design of more effective fatherhood interventions. RCTs are needed that compare no-treatment conditions, father-only conditions, mother-only conditions, and co-parenting couple conditions using the same curricula. A good example of this kind of design in a correlational study (Ryan et al., 2006) supports the argument that data from both parents make a combined contribution to predicting children’s outcomes.

In our reading of the fatherhood literature, we have found intervention studies for fathers of infants, toddlers, school aged children, and adolescents, but not for fathers of adult children. It would be valuable to have comparative studies to examine whether there are developmental aspects of systems models

that would require modification depending on the age of the father and the age of the child.

We acknowledge that intervention studies can only report data on men who are willing to participate and can bring co-parents willing to participate. That is, they are not random samples from the general population. Even though this limitation applies to all fatherhood research, it would be important to identify recruiting procedures that increase the heterogeneity of our current samples of fathers and partners (see Yaremych & Persky, 2023, for an evaluation of 8 recruiting strategies).

Subgroup and Cultural Differences

We are aware both within the United States and other Western industrialized countries and in non-Western countries and cultures that there are profound variations in family structures, gender role stereotypes, and valued parenting practices. There is increasing attention in the research literature to same-sex parents and their children (Golombok, 2015; Panter-Brick et al., 2015; Stacey & Biblarz, 2001), but outside of a few pilot trials we know of no systematically evaluated interventions for lesbian and gay parents to strengthen relationships between partners and between parents and their children. In Western cultures, the high rate of divorce since the 1950s, now leveling off, has led to increased variation in family types—married, divorced, or separated couples who live together or apart, or never married single fathers and single mothers. Similarly, there is a vast literature on variations across cultures in who is responsible for parenting the children—two parents in a nuclear family, primarily mothers, multigenerational parents focused on the same child, or the community in which siblings and other adults are all parental figures (Alvergne & Hrdy, 2011). Much more research is needed on alterations in multidomain models that would provide an appropriate match to the needs of intervention participants.

Cultures and subcultures vary in their stereotypes of what constitutes a father's role (Valiquette-Tessier et al., 2016) or whether fathers are to be engaged in the care of young children at all. These distinctions also vary within subcultures. In China, for example, “strict mother and loving father” co-parenting (Wang et al., 2023) has also been described elsewhere as “strict father and loving mother” (Zemp et al., 2016). Very little is known about which cultures would encourage or even allow fatherhood interventions, and what models of intervention might be acceptable and successful.

Finally, there are important variations in subgroups and across cultures in specific parenting practices that are valued or prohibited. For example, there are cultures in which physical violence as a response to real or imagined

transgressions is normative and sanctioned, and cultures in which it is devalued or forbidden by law (e.g., Childress et al., 2024).

There is clearly no universality to the notion of what “family” is, or to the theoretical models on which intervention designs should be based. We need additional research to determine the extent to which our five-domain model requires modification based on the variations that we have noted here. Nevertheless, we would argue that in all of these variations there are multiple risk and protective factors affecting parenting and children’s developmental outcomes: individual characteristics of the parenting figures, the relationships between parenting figures, the quality of the parent-child relationships, the intergenerational transmission of parenting patterns and arrangements, and factors outside the family system that affect fathering roles.

CONCLUSIONS

We have identified a gap between the results of studies that identify multiple factors associated with the quality of fathering and the narrow focus of most fatherhood interventions on fathers only. We have shown that the gap can be narrowed or closed by adopting a family systems perspective in the design of a curriculum that addresses multiple risk and protective factors that affect fathers’ role in the family. We have described 8 Supporting Father Involvement/Parents as Partners trials, and one single trial of an intervention that includes a couple relationship focus as well as a co-parenting focus in their curriculum. We have also noted reviews of interventions that added fathers but kept the focus on each parent’s relationship to the child. We conclude that fathering is not simply behavior that occurs between a father and his child. In addition to the quality of his direct interaction with the child, fathering is a dynamic product of his well-being, the quality of the relationship with his co-parenting partner, the transmission of behavioral patterns across generations, and the balance between outside-the-family stressors and the supports available to assist in coping with them.

IMPLICATIONS FOR PRACTICE AND POLICY

With respect to practice, our studies and others, and our clinical experience of training many group facilitators and conducting or supervising SFI groups in many countries, suggest that service organizations that offer parenting interventions should, when possible, actively and routinely recruit both parents as participants, even when, or especially when, their ultimate goal is to encourage increased positive engagement of fathers with their children and/or support the family economically. The findings are consistent with the idea that biological parents, non-biological parents, and non-intimate partners experience equal or comparable benefits from participation. Of course, it is not always

possible to recruit both partners/family members to attend intervention sessions together. One partner may be incarcerated, ill, living far away, or simply unwilling to participate. Nevertheless, we believe that the curriculum should address issues of communication and problem-solving between fathers and other caregivers who are involved in rearing the child. The systems focus of the curricular content may serve as a “good enough” model to maximize potential intervention benefits.

We are not aware of data from studies of preventive interventions for fathers or couples that compare individual and group intervention modalities, but we have been impressed by the power of groups to normalize many parental concerns and show the parents that they are not alone. Some participants have remarked that these discoveries have reduced any stigma they feel for having challenging relationships with their partners or their children. Many report versions of discovering with relief that “We’re all in the same boat.” Finally, providing food and childcare while the parents are meeting has added to the family-friendliness of the systems model. In SFI, the children were excited to attend their “play group” while their parents were meeting in theirs.

With respect to policy, first, we relied here primarily on intervention studies that used Randomized Controlled Designs, but we are well aware that policy makers cannot rely solely on RCTs to make decisions about which interventions to fund, for two reasons: (1) RCTs have their own methodological limitations (Cook & Thigpen, 2019; Deaton & Cartwright, 2018), and (2) even more important, very many good ideas for services arise before any systematic evaluations of the ideas have been conducted. Program providers and funders must often rely on findings from correlational studies and their own clinical judgments to create new and innovative fatherhood programs.

Second, it has long been the policy of domestic violence programs to prevent men referred because of violent behavior from engaging with their partners in interventions (Karakurt et al., 2016). Our experience has been that with skilled assessment by facilitators, couples who are not currently involved in violent or abusive interactions can benefit from participating together (see Kline Pruett et al., 2019). Clearly, such decisions must be based on careful screening and individual evaluations of a family.

A third policy implication stems from the fact that in a number of SFI evaluations, fathers and co-parents experienced gains in income and employment. If getting and keeping a job is viewed as a family affair rather than an issue for individual parents, SFI might prove useful in addressing issues of the stress of economic insufficiency as well. This application could counter research showing that in separated families, coparenting without intervention can lead to economic decisions and arrangements that undermine children’s schooling success and economic opportunities as adults (Kranz et al., 2021).

Finally, the current structure of family services is organized into siloed departments that address issues relevant to mothers, children, *or* fathers separately. Staff in these departments rarely communicate and coordinate their findings and programs with one another, so that administrative and service silos create and reinforce barriers to enlisting fathers' participation in family systems intervention. Eliminating some of these structural silos would go a long way toward bringing more fathers into active and positive involvement with their parenting partners and their children. This design would also give the message to mothers, fathers, teachers, and family service providers that fathers are critically important players in the health and development of their families and their children.

AFFILIATIONS AND ADDRESSES

Philip A. Cowan, Department of Psychology, University of California, Berkeley, 3234 Berkeley Way West, Berkeley, California, 94720. Email: pcowan@berkeley.edu Carolyn Pape Cowan is at the University of California, Berkeley, Marsha Kline Pruett is at Smith College School of Social Work, and Kyle Pruett is at the Yale University School of Medicine.

ARTICLE INFORMATION

Conflict of Interest Disclosures

Each author signed a form for disclosure of potential conflicts of interest. No authors reported any financial or other conflicts of interest in relation to the work described.

Ethical Principles

The author/s affirm/s having followed professional ethical guidelines in preparing this work. These guidelines include obtaining informed consent from human participants, maintaining ethical treatment and respect for the rights of human or animal participants, and ensuring the privacy of participants and their data, such as ensuring that individual participants cannot be identified in reported results or from publicly available original or archival data.

Funding

The writing of this review paper was not supported by any funding sources

Acknowledgments

The authors thank the editor and the reviewers for their comments on prior versions of this manuscript. The ideas and opinions expressed herein are those of the authors and not the program service providers.

REFERENCES

- Adler-Baeder, F., Calligas, A., Skuban, E., Keiley, M., Ketrings, S., & Smith, T. (2013). Linking changes in couple functioning and parenting among couple relationship education participants. *Family Relations*, 62(2), 284–297. <https://doi.org/10.1111/fare.12006>
- Alcaniz, L., Martínez-Pampliega, A., & Herrero, M. (2022). Cost-benefit analysis of an intervention in divorced parents: Implications for society, public administrations and family visitation centers. *International Journal of Environmental Research and Public Health*, 19(6), 34–84. <https://doi.org/10.3390/ijerph19063484>
- Altenburger, L. E., & Schoppe-Sullivan, S. J. (2021). Contributions of parenting quality and coparenting relationship quality to the development of child executive functioning. *Early Child Research Quarterly*, 57, 133–143. <https://doi.org/10.1016/j.ecresq.2021.05.010>
- Alvergne, A., & Hrdy, S. B. (2011). Mothers and others: The evolutionary origins of mutual understanding. *Journal of Biosocial Science*, 43(4), 509–511. <https://doi.org/10.1017/S0021932011000113>
- Amato, P. R., & Afifi, T. D. (2006). Feeling caught between parents: Adult children's relations with parents and subjective well-being. *Journal of Marriage & Family*, 68(1), 222–235. <https://doi.org/10.1111/j.1741-3737.2006.00243.x>
- Austin, W. G., Fieldstone, L., & Pruett, M. K. (2013). Bench book for assessing parental gatekeeping in parenting disputes: Understanding the dynamics of gate closing and opening for the best interests of children. *Journal of Child Custody*, 10(1), 1–16. <https://doi.org/10.1080/15379418.2013.778693>
- Avellar, S., Covington, R., Moore, Q., Patnaik, A., & Wu, A. (2018). *Parents and children together: Effects of four responsible fatherhood programs from low-income fathers*. (OPRE report number 2018-50).
- Bakermans-Kranenburg, M. J., Ijzendoorn, M. H. V., & Juffer, F. (2003). Less is more: Meta-analyses of sensitivity and attachment interventions in early childhood. *Psychological Bulletin*, 129(2), 195–215. <https://doi.org/10.1037/0033-2909.129.2.195>
- Baughman, R. A. (2017). The impact of child support on child health. *Review of Economics of the Household*, 15(1), 69–91. <https://doi.org/10.1007/s11150-014-9268-3>
- Baumrind, D. (1971). Current patterns of parental authority. *Developmental Psychology*, 4(1), 1–103. doi 10.1037/h0030372
- Belsky, J. (1984). The determinants of parenting: A process model. *Child Development*, 55(1), 83–96. <https://doi.org/10.2307/1129836>
- Besnard, T., Capuano, F., Verlaan, P., Pulin, F., & Vitaro, F. (2009). Effet ajouté de la participation des pères à une intervention familiale. *Revue de Psychoéducation*, 38(1), 45–71. <https://doi.org/10.7202/1096896ar>
- Bornstein, M. H. (Ed.). (2019). *Handbook of parenting* (3rd ed). Routledge. <https://doi.org/10.4324/9780429440847-1>
- Bowen, M. (1974). Alcoholism as viewed through family systems-theory and family psychotherapy. *Annals of the New York Academy of Sciences*, 233(1), 115–122. <https://doi.org/10.1111/j.1749-6632.1974.tb40288.x>
- Brody, G. H., & Forehand, R. (1985). The efficacy of parent training with maritally distressed and nondistressed mothers: A multimethod assessment. *Behaviour Research and Therapy*, 23(3), 291–296. [https://doi.org/10.1016/0005-7967\(85\)90007-5](https://doi.org/10.1016/0005-7967(85)90007-5)
- Bronfenbrenner, U. (1979). *The ecology of human development: Experiments by nature and design*. Harvard University Press. <https://doi.org/10.4159/9780674028845>
- Bruno, A. C. L., Rizzo, C., Mento, A., Silvestri, M. C., De Stefano, R., & Muscatello, M. R. A. (2020). When fathers begin to falter: A comprehensive review on paternal perinatal

- depression. *International Journal of Environmental Research and Public Health*, 17(4), 1139. <https://doi.org/10.3390/ijerph17041139>
- Cabrera, N. J., Fitzgerald, H. E., Bradley, R. H., & Roggman, L. (2014). The ecology of father-child relationships: An expanded model. *Journal of Family Theory & Review*, 6(4), 336–354. <https://doi.org/10.1111/jftr.12054>
- Cabrera, N. J., Scott, M., Fagan, J., Steward-Streng, N., & Chien, N. (2012). Coparenting and children's school readiness: A mediational model. *Family Process*, 51(3), 307–324. <https://doi.org/10.1111/j.1545-5300.2012.01408.x>
- Cabrera, N. J., Shannon, J. D., & Tamis LeMonda, C. (2007). Fathers' influence on their children's cognitive and emotional development: From toddlers to pre-k. *Applied Developmental Science*, 11(4), 208–213. <https://doi.org/10.1080/10888690701762100>
- Caldera, Y. M., & Lindsey, E. W. (2006). Coparenting, mother-infant interaction, and infant-parent attachment relationships in two-parent families. *Journal of Family Psychology*, 20(2), 275–283. <https://doi.org/10.1037/0893-3200.20.2.275>
- Camara, K. A., & Resnick, G. (1988). *Interparental conflict and cooperation: Factors moderating children's post-divorce adjustment*. Lawrence Erlbaum Associates, Inc.
- Carlson, M. J., McLanahan, S. S., & Brooks-Gunn, J. (2008). Coparenting and nonresident fathers' involvement with young children after a nonmarital birth. *Demography*, 45(2), 461–488. <https://doi.org/10.1353/dem.0.0007>
- Casey, P., Cowan, P. A., Cowan, C. P., Draper, L., Mwamba, N., & Hewison, D. (2017). Parents as partners: A U.K. Trial of a U.S. couples-based parenting intervention for at-risk low-income families. *Family Process*, 56(3), 589–606. <https://doi.org/10.1111/famp.12289>
- Caspi, A., & Elder, G. H. J. (1988). Emergent family patterns: The intergenerational construction of problem behaviour and relationships. In R. A. Hinde & J. Stevenson-Hinde (Eds.), *Relationships within families: Mutual influences* (pp. 218–240). Clarendon Press.
- Chen, E., Brody, G. H., & Miller, G. E. (2017). Childhood close family relationships and health. *The American Psychologist*, 72(6), 555–566. <https://doi.org/10.1037/amp0000067>
- Cheung, K., & Theule, J. (2019). Paternal depressive symptoms and parenting behaviors: An updated meta-analysis. *Journal of Child & Family Studies*, 28(3), 613–626. <https://doi.org/10.1007/s10826-018-01316-1>
- Childress, S., Shrestha, N., Kanykei, K., Jildyz, U., & Schrag, R. V. (2024). The role of culture in the justification and perpetuation of domestic violence: The perspectives of service providers in Kyrgyzstan. *Violence Against Women*, 30(5), 1198. <https://doi.org/10.1177/10778012231186814>
- Cicchetti, D., & Toth, S. L. (2010). Child maltreatment: The research imperative and the exportation of results to clinical contexts. In B. M. Lester & J. D. Sparrow (Eds.), *Nurturing children and families: Building on the legacy of T. Berry Brazelton* (pp. 264–274). Wiley-Blackwell. <https://doi.org/10.1002/9781444324617.ch23>
- Cohen, S., & McKay, G. (2020). Social support, stress and the buffering hypothesis: A theoretical analysis. In S. E. Taylor, J. Singer & A. Baum (Eds.), *Handbook of psychology and health, volume IV* (pp. 253–267). Routledge. <https://doi.org/10.4324/9781003044307-10>
- Conger, K. J., Rueter, M. A., & Conger, R. D. (2000). The role of economic pressure in the lives of parents and their adolescents: The family stress model. In L. J. Crockett & R. K. Silbereisen (Eds.), *Negotiating adolescence in times of social change* (pp. 201–223). Cambridge University Press. <https://doi.org/10.1017/CBO9780511600906.014>
- Cook, C. E., & Thigpen, C. A. (2019). Five good reasons to be disappointed with randomized trials. *The Journal of Manual & Manipulative Therapy*, 27(2), 63–65. <https://doi.org/10.1080/10669817.2019.1589697>

- Cowan, C. P., Cowan, P. A., & Barry, J. (2011). Couples' groups for parents of preschoolers: Ten-year outcomes of a randomized trial. *Journal of Family Psychology*, 25(2), 240–250. <https://doi.org/10.1037/a0023003>
- Cowan, C. P., Cowan, P. A., Heming, G., Garrett, E., Coysh, W. S., Curtis-Boles, H., & Boles, A. J., III. (1985). Transitions to parenthood: His, hers, and theirs. *Journal of Family Issues*, 6(4), 451–481. <https://doi.org/10.1177/019251385006004004>
- Cowan, C. P., Cowan, P. A., Pruett, M. K., & Pruett, K. (2007). An approach to preventing coparenting conflict and divorce in low-income families: Strengthening couple relationships and fostering fathers' involvement. *Family Process*, 46(1), 109–121. *Special Issue: Divorce and Its Aftermath*. <https://doi.org/10.1111/j.1545-5300.2006.00195.x>
- Cowan, P. A., Cowan, C. P., Ablow, J. C., Johnson, V. K., & Measelle, J. R. (Eds.). (2005). *The family context of parenting in children's adaptation to elementary school*. Lawrence Erlbaum Associates. <https://doi.org/10.4324/9781410612885>
- Cowan, P. A., Cowan, C. P., & Gillette, P. F. (2022). True dads: The impact of a couples-based fatherhood intervention on family relationships, child outcomes, and economic self-sufficiency. *Family Process*, 61(3), 1021–1044. <https://doi.org/10.1111/famp.12748>
- Cowan, P. A., Cowan, C. P., Pruett, M. K., Pruett, K., & Gillette, P. (2014). Evaluating a couples group to enhance father involvement in low-income families using a benchmark comparison. *Family Relations: An Interdisciplinary Journal of Applied Family Studies*, 63(3), 356–370. <https://doi.org/10.1111/fare.12072>
- Cowan, P., Cowan, C. P., Pruett, M. K., Pruett, K., & Wong, J. J. (2009). Promoting fathers' engagement with children: Preventive interventions for low-income families. *Journal of Marriage & Family*, 71(3), 663–679. <https://doi.org/10.1111/j.1741-3737.2009.00625.x>
- Cummings, E. M., Merrilees, C. E., & George, M. W. (2010). Fathers, marriages, and families: Revisiting and updating the framework for fathering in family context. In M. Lamb (Ed.), *The role of the father in child development* (pp.154–176).
- Cutrona, C. E. (1996). *Social support as a determinant of marital quality: The interplay of negative and supportive behaviors*. Plenum Press. https://doi.org/10.1007/978-1-4899-1388-3_8
- Dadds, M. R., Schwartz, S., & Sanders, M. R. (1987). Marital discord and treatment outcome in behavioral treatment of child conduct disorders. *Journal of Consulting & Clinical Psychology*, 55(3), 396–403. <https://doi.org/10.1037/0022-006X.55.3.396>
- Deaton, A., & Cartwright, N. (2018). Understanding and misunderstanding randomized controlled trials. *Social Science & Medicine*, 210, 2–21. <https://doi.org/10.1016/j.socscimed.2017.12.005>
- Favez, N., Widmer, E. D., Doan, M.-T., & Tissot, H. (2015). Coparenting in stepfamilies: Maternal promotion of family cohesiveness with partner and with father. *Journal of Child & Family Studies*, 24(11), 3268. <https://doi.org/10.1007/s10826-015-0130-x>
- Feinberg, M. E., & Jones, D. E. (2018). Experimental support for a family systems approach to child development: Multiple mediators of intervention effects across the transition to parenthood. *Couple and Family Psychology: Research and Practice*, 7(2), 63–75. <https://doi.org/10.1037/cfp0000100>
- Feinberg, M. E., Jones, D. E., Roettger, M. E., Solmeyer, A., & Hostetler, M. L. (2014). Long-term follow-up of a randomized trial of family foundations: Effects on children's emotional, behavioral, and school adjustment. *Journal of Family Psychology*, 28(6), 821–831. <https://doi.org/10.1037/fam0000037>
- Feinberg, M. E., & Kan, M. L. (2008). Establishing family foundations: Intervention effects on coparenting, parent/infant well-being, and parent-child relations. *Journal of Family Psychology*, 22(2), 253–263. <https://doi.org/10.1037/0893-3200.22.2.253>
- Fisher, S. D. (2017). Paternal mental health: Why is it relevant? *American Journal of Lifestyle Medicine*, 11(3), 200–211. <https://doi.org/10.1177/1559827616629895>

- Fivaz-Depeursinge, E., & Philipp, D. A. (2014). *The baby and the couple: Understanding and treating young families*. Routledge/Taylor & Francis Group. <https://doi.org/10.4324/9781315779775>
- Fletcher, R. J., Feeman, E., Garfield, C., & Vimpani, G. (2011). The effects of early paternal depression on children's development. *The Medical Journal of Australia*, 195(11–12), 685–689. <https://doi.org/10.5694/mja11.10192>
- Frosch, C. A., Schoppe-Sullivan, S. J., & O'Banion, D. D. (2021). Parenting and child development: A relational health perspective. *American Journal of Lifestyle Medicine*, 15(1), 45–59. <https://doi.org/10.1177/1559827619849028>
- Glasser, S., & Lerner-Geva, L. (2019). Focus on fathers: Paternal depression in the perinatal period. *Perspectives in Public Health*, 139(4), 195. <https://doi.org/10.1177/1757913918790597>
- Golombok, S. (2015). *Modern families: Parents and children in new family forms*. Cambridge University Press. <https://doi.org/10.1017/CBO9781107295377>
- Harold, G. T., & Sellers, R. (2018). Annual research review: Interparental conflict and youth psychopathology: An evidence review and practice focused update. *Journal of Child Psychology and Psychiatry*, 59(4), 374–402. <https://doi.org/10.1111/jcpp.12893>
- Hobbs, D. F., Jr. (1965). Parenthood as crisis: A third study. *Journal of Marriage and the Family*, 27(3), 367–372. <https://doi.org/10.2307/350281>
- Hobbs, D. F., Jr. (1968). Transition to parenthood: A replication and an extension. *Journal of Marriage and the Family*, 30(3), 413–417. <https://doi.org/10.2307/349909>
- Hobbs, D. F., & Cole, D. A. (1976). Transition to parenthood: A decade replication. *Journal of Marriage and the Family*, 38(4), 723–731. <https://doi.org/10.2307/350691>
- Hrdy, S. B. (2024). *Father time: A natural history of men and babies*. Princeton University Press.
- Jensen, A. C., Jorgensen-Wells, M. A., Andrus, L. E., Pickett, J. M., Leiter, V. K., Hadlock, M. E. B., & Dayley, J. C. (2023). Sibling differences and parents' differential treatment of siblings: A multilevel meta-analysis. *Developmental Psychology*, 59(4), 644–654. <https://doi.org/10.1037/dev0001406>
- Jeong-Kyun, C., & Becher, E. H. (2019). Supportive coparenting, parenting stress, harsh parenting, and child behavior problems in nonmarital families. *Family Process*, 58(2), 404. <https://doi.org/10.1111/famp.12373>
- Kan, M. L. P., & Feinberg, M. E. P. (2014). Can a family-focused, transition-to-parenthood program prevent parent and partner aggression among couples with young children? *Violence & Victims*, 29(6), 967–980. <https://doi.org/10.1891/0886-6708.VV-D-12-00162>
- Karakurt, G., Whiting, K., Eesch, C. V., Bolen, S., & Calabrese, J. (2016). Couple therapy for intimate partner violence: A systematic review and meta-analysis. *Journal of Marital & Family Therapy*, 42(4), 567–583. <https://doi.org/10.1111/jmft.12178>
- Keneski, E., Neff, L. A., & Loving, T. J. (2017). The importance of a few good friends: Perceived network support moderates the association between daily marital conflict and diurnal cortisol. *Social Psychological & Personality Science*, 9(8), 962–971. <https://doi.org/10.1177/1948550617731499>
- Khraisha, Q., Sawalha, L., Hadfield, K., Al-Soleiti, M., Dajani, R., & Panter-Brick, C. (2024). Coparenting, mental health, and the pursuit of dignity: A systems-level analysis of refugee father-mother narratives. *Social Science & Medicine*, 340, 116452. <https://doi.org/10.1016/j.socscimed.2023.116452>
- Kline Pruett, M., Cowan, P. A., Cowan, C. P., Gillette, P., & Pruett, K. (2019). Supporting father involvement: A group intervention for low-income community and child welfare referred couples. *Family Relations*, 68(1), 51–67. <https://doi.org/10.1111/fare.12352>
- Knox, V., Cowan, P. A., Pape Cowan, C., & Bildner, E. (2011). Policies that strengthen fatherhood and family relationships: What do we know and what do we need to know?

- The ANNALS of the American Academy of Political and Social Science*, 635(1), 216–239. <https://doi.org/10.1177/0002716210394769>
- Kranz, D. F., Roff, J., & Sun, H. (2021). Can economic incentives for joint custody harm children of divorced parents? Evidence from state variation in child support laws. *Journal of Economic Behavior and Organization*, 189, 1–27. <https://doi.org/10.1016/j.jebo.2021.06.020>
- Lamela, D., Figueiredo, B., Bastos, A., & Feinberg, M. (2016). Typologies of post-divorce coparenting and parental well-being, parenting quality and children's psychological adjustment. *Child Psychiatry and Human Development*, 47(5), 716–728. <https://doi.org/10.1007/s10578-015-0604-5>
- Larzelere, J. R., Morris, A. S., & Harrist, A. (Eds.). (2012). *Authoritative parenting*. American Psychological Association.
- Lawson, M., Piel, M. H., & Simon, M. (2020). Child maltreatment during the COVID-19 pandemic: Consequences of parental job loss on psychological and physical abuse towards children. *Child Abuse and Neglect*, 110, 104709. <https://doi.org/10.1016/j.chiabu.2020.104709>
- LeMasters, E. E. (1957). Parenthood as crisis. *Marriage and Family Living*, 19(4), 352–355. <https://doi.org/10.2307/347802>
- Liu, L., Li, S., Zheng, Y., & Wang, M. (2021). Intergenerational transmission of anxiety in Chinese migrant families: The mediating role of parents' perceptions of coparenting. *Journal of Affective Disorders*, 280, 287–294. <https://doi.org/10.1016/j.jad.2020.10.069>
- Lucassen, N., Tharner, A., Van Ijzendoorn, M. H., Bakermans-Kranenburg, M. J., Volling, B. L., Verhulst, F. C., Lambregtse Van den Berg, M. P., & Tiemeier, H. (2011). The association between paternal sensitivity and infant-father attachment security: A meta-analysis of three decades of research. *Journal of Family Psychology*, 25(6), 986–992. <https://doi.org/10.1037/a0025855>
- Lundahl, B. W., Tollefson, D., Risser, H., & Lovejoy, M. C. (2008). A meta-analysis of father involvement in parent training. *Research on Social Work Practice*, 18(2), 97–106. <https://doi.org/10.1177/1049731507309828>
- Lünnemann, M. K. M., Van der Horst, F. C. P., Prinzie, P., Luijk, M., & Steketee, M. (2019). The intergenerational impact of trauma and family violence on parents and their children. *Child Abuse and Neglect*, 96, 1. <https://doi.org/10.1016/j.chiabu.2019.104134>
- McHale, J. P., Gaskin-Butler, V., McKay, K., & Gallardo, G. (2013). Figuring it out for the child initiative: Fostering coparenting in unmarried expectant African American parents. *Zero to Three*, 33(6), 17–22.–.
- McHale, J. P., Salman-Engin, S., & Coover, M. D. (2015). Improvements in unmarried African American parents' rapport, communication, and problem-solving following a prenatal coparenting intervention. *Family Process*, 54(4), 619–629. <https://doi.org/10.1111/famp.12147>
- McHale, J., Waller, M. R., & Pearson, J. (2012). Coparenting interventions for fragile families: What do we know and where do we need to go next? *Family Process*, 51(3), 284–306. <https://doi.org/10.1111/j.1545-5300.2012.01402.x>
- Mestermann, S., Arndt, M., Fasching, P. A., Beckmann, M. W., Kratz, O., Moll, G. H., Kornhuber, J., Eichler, A., & Nunes, C. (2023). The father's part: Influences of paternal psychopathology and parenting behavior on child and adolescent well-being. *Healthcare*, 11(15), 2119. <https://doi.org/10.3390/healthcare11152119>
- Mikulincer, M., & Shaver, P. R. (2017). *Attachment in adulthood*. Guilford.
- Minuchin, S. (1974). *Families and family therapy*. Harvard University Press. <https://doi.org/10.4159/9780674041127>
- Minuchin, S. (2018). *Families and Family Therapy* (2nd ed.). Routledge. <https://doi.org/10.4324/9780203111673->

- Minuchin, S., & Fishman, H. C. (1981). *Family therapy techniques*. Harvard University Press. <https://doi.org/10.4159/9780674041110>
- Moore, Q., Avellar, S., Patnaik, A., Covington, R., & Wu, A. (2018). *Parents and children together: Effects of two healthy marriage programs for low-income couples*. (OPRE report number 2018-58). R. Office of Planning, and Evaluation, Administration for Children and Families, U.S. Department of Health and Human Services.
- Nepomnyaschy, L., Magnuson, K. A., & Berger, L. M. (2012). Child support and young children's development. *The Social Service Review*, 86(1), 3–35. <https://doi.org/10.1086/665668>
- Panter-Brick, C., Burgess, A., Eggerman, M., McAllister, F., Pruett, K., & Leckman, J. (2015). Practitioner review: Engaging fathers - recommendations for a game change in parenting interventions on a systematic review of the global evidence. *Journal of Child Psychology and Psychiatry*, 22(11), 1187–1212. <https://doi.org/10.1111/jcpp.12280>
- Parke, R. D., Coltrane, S., Duffy, S., Buriel, R., Dennis, J., Powers, J., French, S., & Widaman, K. F. (2004). Economic stress, parenting, and child adjustment in Mexican American and European American families. *Child Development*, 75(6), 1632–1656. <https://doi.org/10.1111/j.1467-8624.2004.00807.x>
- Parke, R. D., & Cookston, J. T. Volling, B. L. & Cabrera, N. J. (2019). Advancing research and measurement on fathering and child development: Commentary: Many types of fathers, many types of contexts: An agenda for future progress in fathering research. *Monographs of the Society for Research in Child Development*, 84(1), 132–146. <https://doi.org/10.1111/mono.12404>
- Patterson, G. R. (2002). The early development of coercive family process. In J. B. Reid, G. Patterson, & G. R. Snyder (Eds.), *Antisocial behavior in children and adolescents: A developmental analysis and model for intervention* (pp. 25–44). American psychological association. <https://doi.org/10.1037/10468-002>
- Pruett, K., & Pruett, M. K. (2009). *Partnership parenting: How men and women parent differently-why it helps your kids and can strengthen your marriage*. Da Capo Press.-.
- Pruett, M., & Johnston, J. R. (2004). Therapeutic mediation with high-conflict parents: Effective models and strategies. In J. Folberg, A. Milne, & P. Salem (Eds.), *Divorce and family mediation: Models, techniques, and applications* (pp. 92–111). Guilford Publications.-.
- Pruett, M. K., Gillette, P., & Pruett, K. D. (2016). Supporting father involvement to promote co-parent, parent and child outcomes in a Canadian context. *Psychology & Psychological Research International Journal*, 1(1), 1–14. <https://doi.org/10.23880/PPRIJ-16000111>
- Rienks, S. L., Wadsworth, M. E., Markman, H. J., Einhorn, L., & Etter, E. M. (2011). Father involvement in urban low-income fathers: Baseline associations and changes resulting from preventive intervention. *Family Relations*, 60(2), 191–204. <https://doi.org/10.1111/j.1741-3729.2010.00642.x>
- Ryan, R. M., Martin, A., & Brooks-Gunn, J. (2006). Is one good parent enough? Patterns of mother and father parenting and child cognitive outcomes at 24 and 36 months. *Parenting: Science & Practice*, 6(2–3), 211–228. <https://doi.org/10.1080/15295192.2006.9681306>
- Satir, V. (1972). *Peoplemaking*. Science and behavior books.
- Schulz, M. S., Pruett, M. K., Kerig, P., & Parke, R. D. Eds. (2009). *Strengthening couple relationships for optimal child development: Lessons from research and intervention*. American Psychological Association <https://doi.org/10.1037/12058-000>
- Shereshesky, P. M., & Yarrow, L. J. (1973). *Psychological aspects of a first pregnancy and early postnatal adaptation*. Raven Press.-.
- Solomon, Z., & Zerach, G. (2020). The intergenerational transmission of trauma: When children bear their father's traumatic past. *Neuropsychiatrie de l'Enfance et de l'Adolescence*, 68(2), 65–75. <https://doi.org/10.1016/j.neurenf.2020.01.004>

- Stacey, J., & Biblarz, T. J. (2001). (How) does the sexual orientation of parents matter? *American Sociological Review*, 66(2), 159–183. <https://doi.org/10.1177/000312240106600201>
- Stanley, S. M., Blumberg, S. L., & Markman, H. J. (1999). Helping couples fight for their marriages: The prep approach. In R. Berger & M. T. Hannah (Eds.), *Preventive approaches in couples therapy* (pp. 279–303). Brunner/Mazel, Inc.
- Steinbach, A. (2023). Coparenting as a mediator between physical custody arrangements and children's mental health. *Family Process*, 63, 284–298. <https://doi.org/10.1111/famp.12844>
- Tamis LeMonda, C. S., & Cabrera, N. J. (2013). *Handbook of father involvement : Multidisciplinary perspectives* (2nd ed). Routledge, Taylor & Francis Group.
- Twenge, J. M., Campbell, W. K., & Foster, C. A. (2003). Parenthood and marital satisfaction: A meta-analytic review. *Journal of Marriage & Family*, 65(3), 574–583. <https://doi.org/10.1111/j.1741-3737.2003.00574.x>
- Valiquette-Tessier, S.-C., Vandette, M.-P., & Gosselin, J. (2016). Is family structure a cue for stereotyping? A systematic review of stereotypes and parenthood. *Journal of Family Studies*, 22(2), 162–181. <https://doi.org/10.1080/13229400.2015.1049955>
- Volling, B. L., & Belsky, J. (1991). Multiple determinants of father involvement during infancy in dual-earner and single-earner families. *Journal of Marriage and the Family*, 53(2), 461–474. <https://doi.org/10.2307/352912>
- Wang, J. Y., Schoppe-Sullivan, S. J., Yan, J., & Yoon, S. (2023). Examining parents' susceptibility: Coparenting relationships and parental involvement in low-income families. *Journal of Marriage and the Family*, 85(2), 458–476. <https://doi.org/10.1111/jomf.12901>
- Watzlawick, P., Bavelas, J. B., & Jackson, D. D. (Eds.). (1967). *Pragmatics of human communication : A study of interactional patterns, pathologies, and paradoxes*. Norton.-.
- Webster-Stratton, C. (1985). The effects of father involvement in parent training for conduct problem children. *Journal of Child Psychology and Psychiatry*, 26(5), 801–810. <https://doi.org/10.1111/j.1469-7610.1985.tb00593.x>
- Yaremych, H. E., & Persky, S. (2023). Recruiting fathers for parenting research: An evaluation of eight recruitment methods and an exploration of fathers' motivations for participation. 23 (1), 1–32. <https://doi.org/10.1080/15295192.2022.2036940>
- Zemp, M., Milek, A., Cummings, E. M., Cina, A., & Bodenmann, G. (2016). How couple- and parenting-focused programs affect child behavioral problems: A randomized controlled trial. *Journal of Child & Family Studies*, 25(3), 798–810. <https://doi.org/10.1007/s10826-015-0260-1>